

Initial Note on 2+1 Dimensional Gravity and Chern-Simons Theory

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Abstract

In this note, I'll start to learn about the Chern-Simons formulation of 2+1 dimensional gravity, following the paper of Witten (1988)[1] . For I'm reading this paper while lacking the knowledge of Basic Chern-Simons Theory and Classical 2+1 Dim Gravity, I'll include some background materials as well as preliminaries.

What shall be note is that this is one of the first attempts to understand the quantum theory of 2+1 dimensional gravity. Many of the results from the paper on quantization need further development. Nevertheless, it is still a good way to start learning about this topic.

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1 Preliminaries I: Topology and Geometry

Here I will give a brief review of some basic concepts in topology that will be useful in understanding the Chern-Simons formulation of 2+1 dimensional gravity. It mainly follows the treatment in

1.1 Homeomorphisms and diffeomorphisms

Consider two topological manifold X and Y . We can define a **homeomorphism** between them:

Definition 1. A *homeomorphism* is a continuous bijection $f : X \rightarrow Y$ with a continuous inverse $f^{-1} : Y \rightarrow X$.

If such a homeomorphism exists, we say that X and Y are **homeomorphic**, denoted as $X \cong Y$. We view the two manifold as "topologically equivalent", meaning they have the same topological properties.

If the manifolds are differential manifolds, we can further define a **diffeomorphism**:

Definition 2. A *diffeomorphism* is a smooth bijection $f : X \rightarrow Y$ with a smooth inverse $f^{-1} : Y \rightarrow X$.

If we focus on 3 dimensional manifolds, there is an important theorem:

Theorem 1. *Moise's Theorem*

For 2 & 3 dimensional manifolds, being homeomorphic is equivalent to being diffeomorphic.

This theorem implies that in 2 and 3 dimensions, the topological structure and the smooth structure are essentially the same. This is not true in higher dimensions, where there exist manifolds that are homeomorphic but not diffeomorphic (exotic spheres).

1.2 Mapping Class Group

1.2.1 Isotopy

We focus on the self-diffeo of one manifold $\mathcal{M}$, $f : \mathcal{M} \rightarrow \mathcal{M}$. We can define an **Isotopy** between two diffeomorphisms:

Definition 3. An *isotopy* between two diffeomorphisms $f, g : \mathcal{M} \rightarrow \mathcal{M}$ is a continuous family of diffeomorphisms $F(s) : \mathcal{M} \rightarrow \mathcal{M}$ for $s \in [0, 1]$ such that $F(0) = f$ and $F(1) = g$. If an Isotopy exists between f and g , we say that they are *isotopic*.

Most diffeos considered in physics are isotopic to identity map, yet there for topologically non-trivial manifolds, there can be diffeos that are not isotopic to identity.

- eg. **Dehn Twist** on torus T^2 : Cut the torus along a non-contractible loop, twist one side by 360° , and then re-glue. This operation cannot be continuously deformed to the identity map.

1.2.2 Mapping Class Group

We can define an equivalence relation using Isotopy and define its equivalent class on the set of self-diffeos of $\mathcal{M}$:

Definition 4. The **Mapping Class Group** (MCG) of a manifold $\mathcal{M}$, denoted as $MCG(\mathcal{M})$, is the group of isotopy classes of self-diffeomorphisms of $\mathcal{M}$.

We can prove that the equivalent class set has a group structure.

The mapping class group of 2 dimensional surfaces is well studied and they are generated by:

- **Dehn Twists** along non-contractible loops.

1.3 Fundamental Group

1.3.1 Definition

Definition 5. *Homotopy Curve*

Consider a series of curves satisfying: $\gamma : [0, 1] \rightarrow M$, $\gamma(0) = x_0$, $\gamma(1) = x_0$. If two curves γ_0, γ_1 can be continuously deformed to each other while keeping the endpoints fixed, we say they are **homotopic**, denoted as $\gamma_0 \simeq \gamma_1$.

Mathematically, there exists a continuous map $F : [0, 1] \times [0, 1] \rightarrow M$ such that:

$$\begin{aligned} F(t, 0) &= \gamma_1(t) \\ F(t, 1) &= \gamma_2(t) \\ F(0, s) &= F(1, s) = x_0. \end{aligned} \tag{1}$$

Definition 6. *Fundamental Group*

For a fixed base point x_0 in a topological space M , the **fundamental group** $\pi_1(M, x_0)$ is the set of equivalence classes of loops $[\gamma]$ based at x_0 under the homotopy relation.

We can prove that the set of equivalence classes has a group structure, with the group operation defined as the concatenation of loops.

Theorem 2. For connected manifolds, the fundamental group is independent of the choice of base point up to isomorphism. Therefore, we often denote it simply as $\pi_1(M)$.

1.3.2 More on Properties

Definition 7. *Simply Connected*

A topological space M is said to be **simply connected** if it is path-connected and its fundamental group is trivial, i.e., $\pi_1(M) = \{e\}$, where e is the identity element.

Theorem 3. *Topological Invariance of Fundamental Group*

If two topological spaces M and N are homeomorphic, then their fundamental groups are isomorphic, i.e., $\pi_1(M) \cong \pi_1(N)$.

Theorem 4. *Fully Characterization of 2D Surfaces by Fundamental Group*

The fundamental group fully characterizes the topology of closed 2-dimensional surfaces. Two closed surfaces are homeomorphic if and only if their fundamental groups are isomorphic.

1.4 Covering Space

1.4.1 Covering Space Definition

We can unwrap the non-contractible loops of a manifold by considering its covering space.

Definition 8. Covering Space

A **covering space** of a topological space M is a topological space $\tilde{M}$ together with a continuous surjective map $p : \tilde{M} \rightarrow M$ such that

- For every point $x \in M$, there exists an open neighborhood U of x such that the preimage $p^{-1}(U)$ is homeomorphic to $U \times \Lambda$, where Λ is a discrete set.

1.4.2 Topology of Covering Space

The surjective map used by defining the covering space can induce a homomorphism between the fundamental groups of the two spaces:

Theorem 5. Induced Homomorphism on Fundamental Groups

Let $p : \tilde{M} \rightarrow M$ be a covering map. Then, for any base point $\tilde{x}_0 \in \tilde{M}$ with $p(\tilde{x}_0) = x_0 \in M$, the map p induces a homomorphism $p_* : \pi_1(\tilde{M}, \tilde{x}_0) \rightarrow \pi_1(M, x_0)$.

This homomorphism is injective but not necessarily surjective. The image of p_* is a subgroup of $\pi_1(M, x_0)$ called the **characteristic subgroup** of the covering space. It only consists of paths that are lifted to $\tilde{M}$ to be loops instead of open curves.

Theorem 6. For a connected manifold, any subgroup of its fundamental group can be realized as the characteristic subgroup of some covering space.

Thus we can classify the covering spaces with the subgroups of the fundamental group.

Definition 9. Universal Covering Space

A **universal covering space** of a topological space M is a covering space $\tilde{M}$ that is simply connected, i.e., its fundamental group is trivial: $\pi_1(\tilde{M}) = \{e\}$. which corresponds to the trivial subgroup of $\pi_1(M)$.

1.5 Quotient Space

1.5.1 Quotient Space Definition

We can construct a new manifold by quotienting a manifold with a group action.

Definition 10. Quotient Space

Given a group G acting on a manifold M . The orbit of a point $x \in M$ under the action of G is the set $G \cdot x = \{g \cdot x | g \in G\}$. The **quotient space** M/G is the set of all orbits of points in M under the action of G , equipped with the quotient topology.

We can define a natural projection from the points in M to their corresponding orbits in M/G . which gives a quotient topology by defining open sets in M/G as those whose preimages under the projection are open in M .

- In general a Quotient Space **May NOT** be a Manifold.

Theorem 7. *Quotient Space as Manifold*

If a group G acts properly discontinuously and freely on a manifold M , then the quotient space M/G is also a manifold.

- **freely:** For any point $x \in M$, if $g \cdot x = x$ for some $g \in G$, then g must be the identity element of G . Equivalently the isotropy group $G_x = \{g \in G | g \cdot x = x\}$ is trivial for all $x \in M$.
- **Properly Discontinuously:**
 - Any two points in different orbits have neighborhoods that do not intersect under the group action.
 - for any point x the isotropy group $G_x = \{g \in G | g \cdot x = x\}$ is finite.
 - For any point $x \in M$, there exists an open neighborhood U of x such that for all $g \in G$ not in the isotropy group G_x , the images $g \cdot U$ do not intersect with U , i.e., $g \cdot U \cap U = \emptyset$. for all $g \in G_x$, we have $g \cdot U = U$.

Definition 11. *Orbifold*

*If a group G acts properly discontinuously but not freely on a manifold M , the quotient space M/G is called an **orbifold**.*

An orbifold is a generalization of manifold with some mild singularities.

We can find a point on M to label the orbits in M/G , the complete set of such points is called a **fundamental region** of the group action.

1.5.2 Topology of Quotient Space

Theorem 8. *Topology of Quotient Space of Simply Connected Manifold*

If M is a simply connected manifold and G is a finite group then we can prove a relation between the fundamental group of the quotient space and the group action:

$$\pi_1(M/G) \cong G. \quad (2)$$

In this case the projection $p : M \rightarrow M/G$ is the universal covering map of the quotient space and M is the universal covering space of M/G .

Theorem 9. *Connected Manifold as Quotient Space*

Any connected manifold M can be represented as the quotient space of its universal covering space $\tilde{M}$ by the action of its fundamental group $\pi_1(M)$:

$$M \cong \tilde{M} / \pi_1(M). \quad (3)$$

Here we define the action of $\pi_1(M)$ on $\tilde{M}$ as: Mapping the loop in M mapped to open path in $\tilde{M}$ back by identifying its endpoints.

Mathematically, this action of $\pi_1(M)$ on $\tilde{M}$ is defined as a **Deck Transformation**:

Definition 12. Deck Transformation

For any $[\gamma] \in \pi_1(M)$ we can define a map $D_{[\gamma]} : \tilde{M} \rightarrow \tilde{M}$, that satisfy $p \circ D_{[\gamma]} = p$. It gives a representation of $\pi_1(M)$ as a group of homeomorphisms of $\tilde{M}$.

1.6 Geometization in 2D

Before we only consider topological manifolds, now we can further consider differential manifolds with riemannian metrics.

1.6.1 Standard Geometries in 2D

In 2 dimensions, there are three standard geometries with constant curvature:

- **Riemann Sphere** $\hat{\mathbb{C}} = \mathbb{C} \cup \infty$ with constant positive curvature metric:

$$ds^2 = \frac{4dzd\bar{z}}{(1 + |z|^2)^2}. \quad (4)$$

- **Complex Plane** $\mathbb{C}$ with flat metric:

$$ds^2 = dzd\bar{z}. \quad (5)$$

- **Hyperbolic Plane** $\mathbb{H}^2 = \{z \in \mathbb{C} | \text{Im}(z) > 0\}$ with constant negative curvature metric:

$$ds^2 = \frac{dzd\bar{z}}{(\text{Im}(z))^2}. \quad (6)$$

1.6.2 Uniformization Theorem

We give out one of the most important theorems in 2D geometry:

Theorem 10. Uniformization Theorem(Pure Topology Version)

Every Surface is homeomorphic (diffeomorphic) to D/Γ , where $D \in \{\hat{\mathbb{C}}, \mathbb{C}, \mathbb{H}^2\}$ and $\Gamma \subset \text{Iso}(D)$ is a properly discontinuously isometry on D .

This is a topological statement, we only say that a topological surface can be represented as a quotient space of one of the three standard geometries. However, with suitable operations we can give the quotient space a constant curvature metric induced from the standard geometry. Thus, we know that:

- Any closed surface can be given a constant curvature metric.
- Classification of such metric = Classification of isometry group actions on the standard geometries.

1.7 Complex Structure in 2D**2 Preliminaries II: 2+1 Dimensional Gravity Fundamentals**

Here I'll talk about a standard set up in studying 2+1 dimensional gravity.

{sec:Prel

2.1 Local Spacetime

The Riemannian curvature of 2+1 dimensional gravity can be written directly in terms of Ricci Tensor and the metric:

$$R_{\mu\nu\rho\sigma} = g_{\mu\rho}R_{\nu\sigma} + g_{\nu\sigma}R_{\mu\rho} - g_{\nu\rho}R_{\mu\sigma} - g_{\mu\sigma}R_{\nu\rho} - \frac{1}{2}(g_{\mu\rho}g_{\nu\sigma} - g_{\mu\sigma}g_{\nu\rho})R \quad (7)$$

Thus if we consider the vacuum Einstein equation $R_{\mu\nu} = 0$, the Riemannian curvature vanishes identically! And if we consider the cosmological constant case $R_{\mu\nu} = \Lambda g_{\mu\nu}$, the Riemannian curvature becomes:

$$R_{\mu\nu\rho\sigma} = \Lambda(g_{\mu\rho}g_{\nu\sigma} - g_{\mu\sigma}g_{\nu\rho}) \quad (8)$$

This is a Riemann Tensor of a constant curvature spacetime.

- When $\Lambda = 0$, the spacetime is locally flat, i.e., locally isometric to Minkowski space $\mathbb{R}^{2,1}$.
- When $\Lambda > 0$, the spacetime is locally de Sitter space dS_3 .
- When $\Lambda < 0$, the spacetime is locally anti-de Sitter space AdS_3 .

2.2 Global Spacetime

However, being locally constant curvature spacetime doesn't mean that the theory is trivial, it may include various global properties. However, we shall ask what kinds of global topology may admit a constant curvature metric as well as a lorentzian structure (for physical spacetime is lorentzian).

The answer is given by the following theorem:

Theorem 11. *Let M be a compact 3 manifold with a flat, time-orientable Lorentzian metric and a purely spacelike boundary. Then M has the topology of:*

$$M \cong [0, 1] \times \Sigma \quad (9)$$

Here Σ is a closed surface homeomorphic to one of the boundary components of M .

Thus the topology of a physical spacetime is fixed by the topology of a initial spacelike slice Σ . In the following context we shall only focus on this kind of spacetime topology.

2.3 Frames and Spin Connections

2.3.1 Definition of Frames and Spin Connections

We can a GR theory using a first order formalism, which use frame (aka vierbein or triad) and spin connection as basic variables instead of metric. This is especially useful in 2+1 dimensional gravity, since it can be reformulated as a Chern-Simons theory.

we define the frame fields

Definition 13. *Frame Fields are a set of orthogonal vectors in the tangent space $e^{\mu a}$ or the one form e_μ^a , which satisfy:*

$$g^{\mu\nu} e_\mu^a e_\nu^b = \eta^{ab}, \quad e_\mu^a e_\nu^b \eta_{ab} = g_{\mu\nu}. \quad (10)$$

We often assume that the frame field admits an inverse $e^\mu{}_a$ satisfying:

$$e^\mu{}_a e_\mu{}^b = \delta_a^b, \quad e_\mu{}^a e^\nu{}_a = \delta_\mu^\nu. \quad (11)$$

This set of vectors definately forms a basis of the tangent space, thus we can consider the connections in this basis. For example, the Christoffel symbols can be written as:

$$\nabla_\mu \partial_\nu = \Gamma_{\mu\nu}^\rho \partial_\rho, \quad \text{or} \quad \nabla_\mu dx^\nu = -\Gamma_{\mu\rho}^\nu dx^\rho \quad (12)$$

Thus, a analogue is to define a connection $\omega_\mu{}^a{}_b$ as

Definition 14. *Spin Connection $\omega_\mu{}^a{}_b$ is defined as:*

$$\nabla_\mu e_\nu{}^a = -\omega_\mu{}^a{}_b e_\nu{}^b \quad (13)$$

The covariant derivative of a vector is a rank (0,2) tensor, thus we know that $\omega_\mu{}^a{}_b$ transforms as a one form in the μ index. Thus:

- Both $e^a = e_\mu{}^a dx^\mu$ and $\omega^a{}_b = \omega_\mu{}^a{}_b dx^\mu$ can be understood as one forms. The inverse of the frame fields can be written as a vector field $e_a = e^\mu{}_a \partial_\mu$.
- We define the lowering and raising of the spin connection indices $\omega_{\mu ab} = \eta_{ac} \omega_\mu{}^c{}_b$.

2.3.2 Lorentz Rotation of Frames

The frame fields are not unique, we can always perform a lorentz rotation on them which gives out another set of frame fields that satisfy the same definition:

$$e^a \rightarrow e'^a = \Lambda^a{}_b e^b, \quad (14)$$

Under this transformation, the spin connection refer to the new frame fields have the following relation with the old one:

$$\omega_\mu{}^a{}_b \rightarrow \omega'_\mu{}^a{}_b = \Lambda^a{}_c \omega_\mu{}^c{}_d (\Lambda^{-1})^d{}_b + \Lambda^a{}_c \partial_\mu (\Lambda^{-1})^c{}_b. \quad (15)$$

In terms of the differential form, this can be written as:

$$\omega^a{}_b \rightarrow \omega'^a{}_b = \Lambda^a{}_c \omega^c{}_d (\Lambda^{-1})^d{}_b + \Lambda^a{}_c d(\Lambda^{-1})^c{}_b. \quad (16)$$

In fact we can see that it behaves as a gauge field. Frame fields can perform a "gauge" transformation as lorentz transformation, and the spin connection behaves as the gauge field corresponding to this "gauge" symmetry.

[\[I think I make the convention correct but it still deserves further check.\]](#)

2.3.3 Cartan Structure Equations

Using the above definitions, we hope to express important geometric quantities such as Riemann curvature Tensor. Moreover, we also notice that the frame fields and the spin connections are not independent, just like the Christoffel symbol can be represented by the metric. We want to:

- Represent the spin connection in terms of the frame fields or at least find a relation between them.
- Represent the Riemann curvature Tensor in terms of the spin connection.

These two goals can be achieved by the Cartan structure equations:

Theorem 12. *Cartan's first structure equation*

If the theory is torsion free, then the frame fields and the spin connection satisfy:

$$D_\omega e^a \equiv de^a + \omega^a_b \wedge e^b = 0, \quad (17)$$

$D_\omega e^a$ is called the gauge covariant derivative of e^a with respect to the spin connection ω .

This can be proved directly from the definition of the covariant derivative and the definition of the spin connection. The torsion free condition makes the lower indices of the Christoffel symbol symmetric, thus it cancels out when doing a exterior derivative.

The solution of this equation gives us a

3 Phase Space of 2+1D Gravity

{sec:Phas

Here we follow witten's paper [1] to study the phase space of 2+1 dimensional gravity.

References

- ¹E. Witten, "2 + 1 dimensional gravity as an exactly soluble system", Nuclear Physics B **311**, 46–78 (1988).